

1 MB as well as a restriction of bandwidth to 20 MB per day. The total amount of uploads and downloads should be less than 20 MB per day.

Brinkster (www.brinkster.com) gives you 30 MB of free Web space. The best part is that it accepts the Zip file format, so you can store just about anything you want by zipping the file first. The sign-up process is lengthy, and the interface cluttered with advertisements.

Angelfire (www.angelfire.com) offers 20 MB of storage, and accepts the Zip and MP3 file formats.

eSmartStart.com (www.esmartstart.com) gives 20 MB, with FTP access. This means that you can upload any file you want, but with a bandwidth limitation of 35 MB per day. You can use an FTP client such as CuteFTP (www.cuteftp.com), WS_FTP (http://www.ipswitch.com/Products/WS_FTP/), or BlazeFTP (<http://www.flashpeak.com/blazeftp/blazeftp.htm>) to make use of the FTP facility. You can also open FTP folders in Internet Explorer by typing 'ftp://username:password@sitename.com'. Once the folder opens, you can drag and drop the files through Windows Explorer.

Similarly, www.fortunecity.com gives 25 MB of free space with FTP access. The FTP address is <ftp://username:password@ftp.fortunecity.com>. You can use 'ftp://username:password@ftp.fortunecity.com' to access your folder with Internet Explorer.

Speak a thousand words

Until recently, the obvious choice for online photo albums was Yahoo Photos, but according to a notification on the site, this free service is going to be made very limited soon. Thus we're forced to look for other options.

Sony's Image Station (www.imagestation.com) is good place to store images and videos online. You can upload images in JPEG format and videos in MPEG format. The individual file size limit for JPG images is 6 MB, while it is 40 MB for videos. You can choose between the standard Web interface to upload your files (maximum 30 at a time), or just e-mail the files as an attachment to a specific e-mail address. In the former, you can install a tool that lets you drag and drop.

Another good Web site is Kodak's www.ofoto.com. This place gives you unlimited space for storing your pictures for 12 months—more if you order prints from here. You can also share your photographs by inviting your friends through an e-mail sent by ofoto.



Kodak's ofoto.com offers you unlimited storage for one year

Fotopic.net (<http://fotopic.net>) gives you 250 MB of space to store your photographs, but even if you use up all this space, you can request for more. When you create photo albums, you get weekly statistics about the viewers. You can also access the galleries from your WAP enabled mobile phone. You can choose to upload photos by the Web interface, by sending an e-mail with the pictures as attachments to upload@fotopic.net, or use the FTP access.



Photos stored at Fotopic.net can viewed on your mobile phone

Photodex PictureCD.com (www.picturecd.com) is another site which offers unlimited space for storing photographs. There is only one way to upload photographs to this site, the Web interface. Whenever a photo is uploaded, you get the option to keep the photo private, or make it public. This allows easy sharing of photographs. The only drawback is that you can upload only one image at a time.

Shutterfly (www.shutterfly.com) is a well-known service for online storage of photographs. To upload photographs, just install a tool from the site. Using this tool, you



Photodex PictureCD.com gives you the option of keeping photos public or private

can select multiple pictures to upload, get the upload progress status, and drag and drop the images from Windows Explorer.

Photogra.com (www.photogra.com) also offers unlimited space to store your photographs online. It allows you to create public as well as private albums. www.photoisland.com on the other hand, offers only 10 MB of space to store the photographs online, but has some cool tools such as an event-specific album creation wizard and sending your photos as an e-card.

Points to ponder

There is one more thing you can do to store your documents—e-mail them as attachments to yourself, and keep them in your mailbox. You should use services that give you larger e-mail storage space—10 MB or more, such as HushMail (www.hushmail.com), Fast Mail (www.fast-mail.fm) and Arabia mail (www.arabia.com).

There are a few things that you need to keep in mind when storing your data online. First, remember that transfer time matters, especially if you are using a dial-up connection. If the file you want to upload is large and the Web site allows compressed files, compress your files using WinZip or other such utilities. Secondly, remember that most of these file transfers aren't very secure, so avoid storing sensitive documents on the Internet. Another concern is the reliability of these sites; earlier, most of these sites were free, but with the ever changing business and Internet scenario, Sites are increasingly becoming paid, or just shutting shop. To counter this, you should store important files at more than one site, so that you can gain access to the data as and when you need it. Also, read the copyright policies carefully and check whether you are abiding by them. ■

UPENDRA SINGHAI

upendra_singhai@thinkdigit.com